

Of course, there's more to the story. Take West Virginia. On the surface of things, West Virginia and Switzerland are almost twins. Both are mountainous. Both are landlocked in the middle of great economies. Both are inhabited almost exclusively by people of European descent.

But the similarities end there. In terms of resources, Switzerland is poor. West Virginia is very rich. While Switzerland has little timber, little arable farmland, and few mineral resources, West Virginia has almost unlimited supplies. Its oil and gas resources, for example, could power the entire United States for more than 100 years. It doesn't have wide, flat fields, but compared with Switzerland, it has much more useful, fertile farmland; its mountains are not as high or steep. It also has timber and water resources in abundance.

Oddly, in terms of earnings and net worth, there is an even further divergence, but in the opposite sense: The people of Switzerland are the richest in the world. The people of West Virginia, however, are among America's poorest. How could that be?

We don't know. But the cultures are quite different. Switzerland evolved a forward-looking, patient, and self-sacrificing culture. Perhaps it was the long, snowy winters that exaggerated the "prepare, prepare, prepare" culture. The Swiss build houses out of concrete, stone and solid wood, according to the toughest building codes in the world. They even have to have bomb shelters . . . with food and supplies stocked up against disaster. They also have, per capita, the biggest intergenerational wealth transfers in the world.

We know West Virginia fairly well. It is perhaps our favorite state. But it is also a puzzlement. There are rocks and trees everywhere. Compared with the soft, funny-shaped rocks of Poitou, France, where we've spent years repairing stone walls, the rocks in West Virginia are a stonemason's dream. They are hard ... and often rectangular. They practically lay themselves.

As for the timber, imagine the envy in a Swiss woodsman's eyes when he sees it. The old hardwood forests of Switzerland must have been cut down centuries ago. What is left is controlled growth, mostly conifers, which have nice qualities of their own, but are in no way equal to the majestic oaks, beeches, and hickories of West Virginia's green hills.